“God is like my father (or mother).”

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Where it often comes from

Childhood experiences with a parent who was harsh, distant, critical, absent, unpredictable, or abusive. Learning about God mainly through how your parents treated you. Hearing God called “Father” and feeling fear, anger, or emptiness instead of comfort. Even loving parents are imperfect, and their weaknesses can shape how we picture God.

What Scripture teaches

Earthly parents, even good ones, are imperfect. God is the perfect Father. Jesus said that if imperfect parents know how to give good gifts, how much more will your Father in heaven give good things to those who ask. God is a father to the fatherless, has compassion on His children, and leads with cords of kindness. Even if a mother could forget her child, God will not forget you. Though father and mother forsake you, the LORD will receive you.

> *“So if you who are evil know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father in heaven give good things to those who ask Him!”* **(Matthew 7:11)**.

Also see

> “Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me” **(Psalm 27:10)**.

> “‘Can a woman forget her nursing child, or lack compassion for the son of her womb? Even if she could forget, I will not forget you!’” **(Isaiah 49:15)**.

> “As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him” **(Psalm 103:13)**.

> “I led them with cords of kindness, with ropes of love; I lifted the yoke from their necks and bent down to feed them” **(Hosea 11:4)**.

Common self-statements

- God is distant, just like my dad was.
- God is always angry, like my father.
- God is never satisfied, like my mother.
- God will leave, like my parent did.
- I can’t trust God because I couldn’t trust my parents.
- God is unpredictable, like the people who raised me.

Common logical errors

- **Projection:** Assuming God has the same faults as your parents.
- **Overgeneralization:** Turning one relationship into a picture of every father, including God.
- **Emotional reasoning:** Concluding “God feels like my parent, so He must be like my parent.”
- **Mental filter:** Ignoring what Scripture says about God’s character.

Challenging questions

- In what ways do I picture God like my father or mother?
- What does Matthew 7:11 say about how much better God is than earthly parents?
- What does Psalm 27:10 promise if my parents forsook me?
- Is my picture of God coming from Scripture or from my childhood?
- What qualities of God in Scripture are different from my parents?
- Can I grieve what my parents didn't give me and still receive it from God?
- What would it be like to have a perfect Father?

Truth summary

> God is not like my father or mother. Earthly parents are imperfect; God is the perfect Father. He is compassionate, kind, faithful, and never forgets me. Even if my parents failed or forsook me, the LORD receives me. I can let Scripture, not my childhood, show me who God really is.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Love, By God
- God, All Loving
- Parenting
- Children
- Trust

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Love
- Parenting

Listen: Overcoming Depression

> **Overcoming Depression** · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "God is like my father (or mother)"

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Read through each section and **check the one that fits you best**. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ **Date started:** _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"God is like my father (or mother)." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ How do I picture God like my parent?
- ☐ How much better is God than earthly parents?
- ☐ What does God promise if my parents forsook me?
- ☐ Is my picture of God from Scripture or childhood?
- ☐ How is God different from my parents?
- ☐ What would a perfect Father be like?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God is the perfect Father.
- ☐ Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me.
- ☐ God will never forget me.
- ☐ God has compassion on me like a loving father.
- ☐ God leads me with kindness and love.
- ☐ My heavenly Father gives good things to me.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- [ ] **Matthew 7:11**
  "So if you who are evil know how to give good gifts to your children, how much more will your Father in heaven give good things to those who ask Him!"
- [ ] **Psalm 27:10**
  "Though my father and mother forsake me, the LORD will receive me."
- [ ] **Isaiah 49:15**
  "'Can a woman forget her nursing child, or lack compassion for the son of her womb? Even if she could forget, I will not forget you!'"
- [ ] **Psalm 103:13**
  "As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him."
- [ ] **Hosea 11:4**
  "I led them with cords of kindness, with ropes of love; I lifted the yoke from their necks and bent down to feed them."

A verse I found myself: _____

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HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first three. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ **Make my Truth Card** (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ **Memorize my Scripture** from Step 4.
- ☐ **Set reminders** to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ **A buzz:** my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ **An everyday event:** every time I _____
  - ☐ **A visual reminder:** something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ **Perfect Father log:** Each day, write one quality of God from Scripture and how it differs from my earthly parent.
- ☐ **My name in Scripture:** Rewrite my verse with my name in it and read it aloud each morning.
  *For example, Psalm 27:10 becomes: "Though **Sarah's** father and mother forsake **her**, the LORD will receive **her**."*
- ☐ **Gratitude journal:** Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ **Truth recording:** Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ **Reading:** The "God, All Loving" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ **Listening:** The Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

- ☐ **Make two columns:** "My parent was..." and "God is...", and fill in the second with verses.
- ☐ **Read Luke 15:11–32,** and write how the father in the story is different from your parent.
- ☐ **Pray to God as Father this week,** telling Him honestly how hard that word may feel.
- ☐ **Talk with a counselor or pastor** about how your parents shaped your picture of God.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

What I learned: _____

The lie "God is like my father (or mother)": _____ % **My truth:** _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	One way God is better than my parent
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~God is like my father (or mother).~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Heavenly Father, thank You that You are the perfect Father. Help me reject the lie that You are like my earthly father or mother. Heal the hurts my parents caused, and show me who You really are: compassionate, kind, faithful, and always present. Teach me to trust You as Your child. In Jesus' name, Amen.

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Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.